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Writers, January, 2006

HERE SHE COMES.....MRS. AMERICA !

As I approached Mar Vista Market in West Los Angeles that lovely Spring day in 1962, I noticed a large crowd gathering in the parking lot. My breath quickened as I envisioned an outdoor sale of bargains. Or, I thought with accelerated excitement, it might be a contest. I squiggled closer to the action and saw a familiar man speaking on a microphone. Although, I couldn't recall his name, and still can't, I had seen him on television programs.

Mr. X was explaining that they were planning to conduct a Mrs. America contest and selected residents, of the female persuasion, would have a chance to participate, first in the Mrs. California competition, and later in the national pageant.

"Is it a bathing suit contest?" a plump lady inquired.

"No ma'am," answered suave Mr. X. He was getting handsomer by the minute. "This is a competition for married women, who like to cook, serve in community affairs, have hobbies and poise. There will be many prizes for the winners."

"But what does she have to wear?" asked Mrs. Zoftig (chubby) as she munched on a candy bar.

"There is one evening gown event, but most of the time it's casual attire."

"So, why are you here?" a fairly attractive, dark at the roots, blonde queried.

"I'm here to interview a few women who might want to join the fun." said Mr. Gorgeous.

Several women screamed and jumped with joy, and others, including my eager self, raised our hands straight up. He beckoned to me and four or five others, and one at a time, proceeded to ask

questions. I noticed that an official looking gentleman nearby was taking notes so when my turn came, my size ten posture was never better. Most of the questions were about my interests, number of children, type of cooking I enjoy (the Greek recipes made a good impression.) and if I revel in decorating my home.

At the conclusion, he said that the elected participants would be

notified. I was so exalted that I almost forgot to shop for dinner. There was much discussion around the dinner table about my experience.

In two days, I received a phone call from the television studio saying that they would like me to represent Mrs. Studio City, as there was already someone representing Mar Vista.

“I love Studio City”, I exclaimed, although I had never been there.

The plan was to attend an orientation at the Ambassador Hotel; very classy indeed. We then had two weeks to prepare for the final competition, which would include three days of special activities, including a parade the evening gown event and a live interview.

My youngest son had just entered first grade so I had a little time for the new project. My wardrobe was not Mrs. America material so I made a bee-line to Penny’s. Happily, my sister-in-law was the head of alterations at the local May Company. Sweetie pie Rae, was very glad to lend her expertise, and she made the clothing fit like a velvet glove.

Preparing a main dish was the first event. All of the ingredients were provided for, with a portion of the extravagant kitchen of the Ambassador Hotel to use as we wished. They got the grape leaves that I requested, and everything else that went into my dolmadas recipe. It came out scrumptious, and my Greek mother-in-law would have proudly spit three times in my direction.

Making festive centerpieces was the next challenge and we were provided with a budget to get our own materials. I went to a party shop and bought sparkly fronds and other fun things. It turned out great and I duplicated twelve more two years later when we planned my older son’s bar-mitzvah reception.

We had a parade the next day, in vintage cars. This event could be seen on television, so we were advised to wear pretty hats and wave our gloved hands a great deal. Many of my neighbors saw that show and reported to me the next day, how excited they were to recognize me.

Evening gowns and televized interviews came the following day, and my sis-in-law, Rae was more nervous than I was. That beautiful Alice-blue gown was practically sewn on me, and by necessity, my height increased an extra inch. We knew that our hobbies and interests would be discussed, and as the prime barber in the family, I figured out that I had saved $1400 by clipping the tresses of my husband and four kids. My art

work and weird healthy recipes brought some laughter. I felt confident while Ralph Edwards, the master of ceremonies talked with me, and could hardly wait for the four finalists to be declared.

The third runner up alludes me but the second runner up was the tall, attractive African American wife of a famous basketball player. My name was called next as the first runner up, with the title of Mrs. California going to an OK looking woman who had eight children. I know it sounds like sour grapes because it was.

All in all, it was a memorable event that will stay with me for a long time. My kids were pseudo celebrities for awhile. Now, when I hear that song, “Here She Comes, Miss America”, I realize the tension and exhilaration (and disappointment) that goes into it. The big main difference is that today, they all have plastic surgery, and you know where !!

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